

Editor-in-Chief: Aroon Purie
Chief Executive Officer: Ashish Bagga

Editor: Prabhu Chawla
Managing Editors: Raj Chengappa, Dilip Bobb, Shankar Aiyar
Editor-at-Large: S. Prasannarajan, Executive Editor: Kaveri Bamzai
Deputy Editors: Farzand Ahmed, Damayanti Datta, Ashok K. Damodaran, Sharda Ugra
Senior Editors: Saurabh Shukla, MUMBAI: Malini Bhupta, HYDERABAD: Amarnath K. Menon
Photo Editor: Bhandeep Singh
Art Editor: Sapna Kapoor
Associate Editors: Bhavna Vij-Aurora, S. Sahaya Ranjit, Priya Sahgal, Sandeep Unnithan, AHMEDABAD: Uday Mahurkar, CHANDIGARH: Ramesh Vinayak, LUCKNOW: Subhash Mishra
Assistant Editors: Nivedita Mukherjee, THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: M.G. Radhakrishnan, KOLKATA: Elora Sen
Special Correspondents: Shafi Rahman, JAIPUR: Rohit Parihar, BANGALORE: Nirmala Ravindran
Principal Correspondents: Mihir Srivastava, Nandini Vaish, BANGALORE: Stephen David, Swagata Sen; BHOPAL: Ambresh Mishra, MUMBAI: Jhilmil Motihar, Aditi Patil; PATNA: Amitabh Srivastava
Copy Desk: Nardeep Singh Dahiya (Senior Editor), Anamika Chatterjee, Kaushik Deka, Rahul Kumar, Anika Mohla, Sangram Keshari Parhi, Shilpi, Priyanka Sood, Shveta Srivastava, Rahul Tewari, Priya Verma, Anju Yadav
Photo Department: Hemant Chawla, Sipra Das, Yasbanti Negi, Ravi Sahani, Vikram Sharma, Reuben Singh, AHMEDABAD: Shailesh Raval, CHENNAI: H.K. Rajashekar, MUMBAI: Mandar Deodhar, Shriya Patil, Bhaskar Paul, Rashmi Hajela (Chief Photo Researcher)
Infographics and Illustrations: Saurabh Singh
Art Department: Madhu Bhaskar (Art Director), Ranjita Bhattacharji, Vandana Nayar, Jyoti K. Singh (Deputy Art Directors), Rashedi Ajmani Girdhar, Vipin Gupta, Pushvinder Kaur, Madhumangal Singh
Production Department: Surinder Hastu (Chief of Production), Harish Aggarwal, Naveen Gupta

Publishing Director: Malcolm D. Mistry
Associate Publisher: Manoj Sharma (Impact)

IMPACT TEAM

Senior General Manager: Upendra Wellingkar (West and South)
General Managers: Kaustav Chatterjee (East), V. Somasundaram (Chennai), Preeti Kohli (North), Jitendra Lad (West)
Deputy General Manager: Viswanath C.V. (Bangalore)

Consumer Marketing Services: Poonam Sangha, Senior General Manager

Sales and Operations: Vivek Gaur, Executive Director
D.V.S. Rama Rao, Senior General Manager
Vinod Das, General Manager (Sales)
Deepak Bhatt, General Manager, Sales (North)
Rajesh Menon, General Manager, Sales (West)
M. Krishna Kiran, Deputy General Manager, Sales (South)
S. Sridhar, General Manager (Operations)



Volume XXXIV Number 19: For the week
May 5-11, 2009, released on May 4

• Editorial Office Living Media India Ltd. F-14/15, Connaught Place New Delhi 110001; Phones: 23315801-4; Fax: 23316180; Cable: Livmedia, New Delhi
• Subscriptions: For assistance contact Customer Care India Today Group, A-61, Sector-57, Noida (UP)-201301; Phones: Toll-free number: 1800 1800 100 (from BSNL/MTNL/Inet); (95120) 2479900 from Delhi and Faridabad; (0120) 2479900 from Rest of India (Monday-Friday, 10 a.m.-6 p.m.); Fax: (0120) 4078080; e-mail: aroon@indiatoday.com; Mumbai: 022-2444423-6; Fax: 24444358 • Sales: Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited, 201 Connaught House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi • Regd. Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre, 2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013; Phone: 24983355; Fax: 24982266 • Hamilton House, 1-A, Connaught Place, New Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai, 2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177 Into In; Fax: 28472178; Cable: Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448, 22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52, Jawaharlar Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22823398; Fax: 22827254; Cable: Livmedia, Kolkata • 6-3-885/7R, Somajiguda, Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481, 23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 • 39/1045, Karakatt Road, Kochi 682016; Phones: 2377057, 2377058; Fax: 2377059 • 2/C, "Suryarath Bldg", 2nd Floor, Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006; Phone: 26560393, 26560929; Fax: 26565293 • Copyright Living Media India Ltd. All rights reserved throughout the world. Reproduction in any manner is prohibited. Printed and published by Ashish Bagga on behalf of Living Media India Ltd. Printed at Thomson Press India Ltd., 18-35 Milestone, Delhi Mathura Road, Faridabad-121007, (Haryana); A-9, Industrial Complex, Maraimahil Nagar, district Kancheepuram-603209, (Tamil Nadu); and at Plot No. 5-5A, TTC Industrial Area, Thane, Belapur Road, Airoli, Navi Mumbai-400708, (Maharashtra). Published at K-9, Connaught Circus, New Delhi-110001.
• INDIA TODAY does not take the responsibility for returning unsolicited publication material.

All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of competent courts and forums in Delhi/New Delhi only



For reprint rights and syndication enquiries, contact
syndications@indiatoday.com or call +91-120-4078000
www.syndicationtoday.in

From the editor-in-chief

The election campaign for the 15th Lok Sabha has been one of the most noisy and rancorous in recent memory. It has also been one of the most disappointing. It has consisted of predictable personal attacks, more volume than content, always preferring heat to light. There is more discussion about a slippery Italian oil executive than on the state of the economy. More attention was given to the shifting of the IPL overseas than the abysmal state of our education and health services.

Demands were made for a US presidential election-style debate but I suspect that was probably only for its showbiz quotient. Certainly, there has been no worthy debate of any other kind. Other than the issue of who will seize power, this has been an election without an issue.

India is at a very critical moment in its history: its population is over a billion people; its economy just about hovering at the trillion-dollar mark and yes, it is undergoing its most serious economic crisis since the advent of liberalisation. The security situation is dire internally and externally. Naxalites are active in 200 districts inside the country and we are surrounded by both failed and failing states.

The next government will have its hands full. It will need to act, and act swiftly to resolve all manner of crises at our door. Manifestos have tended to be far too general and populist. One memorable manifesto promised the abolition of computers and the English language, which tells you how divorced political parties are from reality and the aspirations of the Indian people. Every party has a multi-crore slick advertising campaign promoting itself, but no one has promoted a cohesive, well-considered agenda for the nation which deals with our myriad problems.

Governance has become a secondary issue for all political parties and their politics has been reduced to a personality contest—and that too without any towering personalities.

In view of the paucity of any substantive issues being presented to the electorate, we decided to prepare an agenda for the nation. In our cover story this week we asked experts to set out their national agenda across various fields where the new government needs to show intent within days of assuming office. The cover story lists eight specific agendas: the economy, security, infrastructure, education, health, employment generation, the justice system and legal reform. Some of the best minds in these areas present to us their action plans for the next government.

Among the experts, National Knowledge Commission Chairman Sam Pitroda writes about the need to re-educate our education system into becoming more relevant to employment. Kumar Mangalam Birla, a scion of one of the oldest Indian business houses, wants the government to spend to create demand to further drive investment and raise growth. Metro czar E. Sreedharan believes we can change the face of India if we find leadership and forge commitment to create world-class infrastructure.

As the essays came in, we were struck by the clarity of thought in every one of them. India's problems are many and daunting, but these essays remind us that they are not insurmountable. We can only hope that the new government shares our view and pays heed to dealing with issues that affect people's lives.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR JANUARY
2009 COVER